

State	Statewide handyman license?	Statewide GC license (threshold)	Unlicensed \$ threshold (general work)	Plumbing	Electrical	HVAC	Consumer / home-improvement contract law	Early Bird Implication	Key notes	Research status	Primary source(s)
Alabama	No (for general/cosmetic work)	Yes — commercial ≥ \$50,000; residential home-builder > \$10,000	< \$10,000 residential general work	State	State	State	No specific home-improvement \$ threshold found; general Deceptive Trade Practices Act.	Caution	General work fine under \$10k, but plumbing/electrical/HVAC are STATE-licensed with NO small-job exemption.	Complete	servicetitan.com; hacz.alabama.gov
Alaska	Yes — state registration for virtually all paid work	Yes — GC registration above handyman cap (\$25k bond)	-\$0 (registration always required); Handyman tier ≤ \$10,000	State	State	State	No \$ threshold for written contract, 5-day cancel for in-home solicited sales	Restrictive	No \$ threshold for written contract, 5-day cancel for in-home solicited sales	Complete	servicetitan.com; law.alaska.gov
Arizona	No — statutory handyman exemption (ARS 32-1121)	Yes — AZ ROC; triggered at \$1,000 or when a permit is required	< \$1,000 combined labor+materials (no permit, no advertising as licensed)	State (ROC)	State (ROC)	State (ROC)	No broad written-contract \$ statute; 3-day cancel for in-home solicited sales	Favorable	Standout: the \$1,000 exemption covers the trades too, so general minor like-for-like trade repairs under \$1,000 (no permit) are exempt.	Complete	roc.az.gov; azcommerce.com
Arkansas	Partial — Home Improvement Specialty License over threshold	Yes — commercial ≥ \$50,000; residential licensed separately	< \$2,000 residential general work	State	State	State	Home Solicitation Sales Act — 3-day cancel > \$25; 'no license, no sue' rule	Caution	General work exempt ≤ \$2,000, but plumbing/electrical/HVAC need separate STATE specialty licenses at ANY value	Complete	labor.arkansas.gov; arkansasag.gov
California	No dedicated handyman license (handyperson below cap only)	Yes — CSLB threshold \$1,000 (AB 2622, eff. 1/1/2025, up from \$500)	< \$1,000 (only if no permit AND no employees on the job)	State (CSLB C-36)	State (CSLB C-10 + electrician cert.)	State (CSLB C-20)	BAP §7159 — written contract > \$500; deposit cap = lesser of \$1,000 or 10%	Caution	\$1,000 exemption is real but fragile — voided by any permit or any hired helper. Gate jobs by permit, not just price.	Complete	cslb.ca.gov (AB 2622 bulletin)
Colorado	No	No statewide GC license — licensed municipality-by-municipality	No statewide cap (varies by municipality)	State (DORA)	State (DORA)	Local (city/county)	No statewide home-improvement contract; general Consumer Protection Act	Mixed / caution	Plumbing & electrical state-regulated (DORA); HVAC + GC are a local patchwork — effort scales with # of cities served.	Complete	colorado.gov; housecallpro.com
Connecticut	Yes — Home Improvement Contractor (HIC) registration for contractors > \$200	No competency license (register + business license)	< \$200 (HIC exempt)	State (DOP)	State (DOP)	State (DOP)	CT Home Improvement Act §20-418+ — written contract > \$200, 3-day cancel, HIC # required	Caution	Registration cheap/easy but the \$200 threshold catches nearly every job; trade work needs a separate state trade license.	Complete	portal.ct.gov/dop
Delaware	Partial — business + AG consumer registration; no competency license	No competency license (register + business license)	Low / uncertain (~\$500 aggregate — verify 6 Del.C. §2572)	State (DePROS)	State (DePROS)	State (DePROS)	Home Improvement Protection Act 6 Del.C. §2571-2577 — written contract above threshold; deposit cap 1/3	Favorable →	No skill-based license for general work (just registration); trade work needs state licenses; mind 1/3 deposit cap	Complete	revenue.delaware.gov; attorneygeneral.delaware.gov
Florida	No	Yes — DBPR/CCLB (Certified + Statewide, Registered = local)	< \$2,500 commercial (does NOT cover trades)	State	State	State	Fis. Stat. §489.120-128 — deposit > 10% triggers permit/standstill; no clear written-contract \$ threshold	Restrictive	Electrical/plumbing/HVAC are state-licensed with NO minor-repair carve-out — even trivial work needs a licensed pro.	Complete	fsenate.gov (Ch. 489); myfloridalicense.com
Georgia	No	Yes — State Licensing Board for Residential & General Contractors; threshold \$2,500	≤ \$2,500 general contractor (not trades)	State	State (low-voltage/networking also licensed)	State (Conditioned Air)	No prominent statewide home-improvement \$ threshold; most cities require occupational license	Caution — restrictive	No-trade work under \$2,500 workable, but plumbing/electrical/conditioned-air AND low-voltage/networking are state-licensed at any value	Complete	sos.ga.gov; O.C.G.A. §43-14-8
Hawaii	No — casual/minor exemption (HRS 444-2)	Yes — state contractor license required for work over \$1,500	< \$1,500 total (void if a permit is required)	State (DCCA / C-37)	State (DCCA / C-13)	State (C-52 specialty)	HRS 444-2.5 — written contract for licensed home-improvement; no \$ threshold	Restrictive	\$1,500 cap collapses whenever a permit is needed; trade repairs still need state-licensed trades.	Complete	cca.hawaii.gov
Idaho	No — 'casual/minor' exemption only	No exam GC; state Contractor Registration (RCR) required at \$2,000	< \$2,000 aggregate per single undertaking (no splitting)	State (DOPL)	State (DOPL)	State (DOPL)	No notable home-improvement written-contract statute (verify locally)	Restrictive	The \$2,000 exemption does NOT cover plumbing/electrical/HVAC — those need state trade licenses regardless.	Complete	dopl.idaho.gov
Illinois	No state handyman license/exemption	No statewide GC license; local (Chicago requires GC where permits needed)	None statewide; varies by municipality	State (IDPH, statewide) + Chicago city license	Local (city/county)	Local (no statewide)	Home Repair & Remodeling Act — written contract over \$1,000 (perimeter over \$500)	Mixed / caution	Plumbing is state-licensed statewide; electrical/HVAC/handyman rules are municipal and vary by city.	Complete	idph.illinois.gov; 815 LICS 513
Indiana	No	No statewide GC license — regulated locally (city/county)	No state cap; local licensing in some cities	State (PLA / Plumbing Commission)	Local (city/county)	Local (city/county)	Home Improvement Contracts Act (HICA) IC 24-5-11 — written contract > \$150, 3-day cancel	Favorable	No state handyman license; plumbing is the only STATE-licensed trade; electrical/HVAC local. See detailed Vol. 1 profile.	Complete (Vol. 1 profile)	in.gov/pls; IC 24-5-11
Iowa	No — contractor registration if ≥ \$2,000/yr	No GC license; state registration required ≥ \$2,000/yr (Ch. 91C)	< \$2,000/yr in construction work	State (PMSB, Ch. 105)	State (Ch. 103; appliance plug-in exempt)	State (PMSB)	Daniel-Door Sales Act (Ch. 555A) — 3-day cancel on home sales ≤ \$25	Restrictive	Plumbing/electrical/HVAC need state trade licenses even if minor; networking & appliance plug-in largely exempt.	Complete	dial.iowa.gov
Kansas	No state license; regulated by county/city	No state GC license; local permit/registration vary	Varies by county (e.g., Sedgwick \$2,500; no state minimum)	Local (county/city)	Local (county/city)	Local (county/city)	Kansas Consumer Protection Act; no notable written-contract \$ trigger	Favorable	No statewide licensing at all — but you must map each county/city/HVAC trade rules.	Complete	housecallpro.com; statearequirement.com
Kentucky	No state license; some cities register contractors	No state GC license; local (Louisville, Bowling Green)	No statewide; set locally	State	State	State	No notable state written-contract \$ threshold (verify locally)	Mixed / caution	GC-free, but electrical/plumbing/HVAC are state-licensed trades.	Complete	servicetitan.com; procore.com
Louisiana	No license under \$7,500 residential	Yes — residential ≥ \$75,000; commercial ≥ \$50,000	< \$7,500 residential (no reg.); \$7,500-\$75,000 = Home Improvement registration	State (LA Plumbing Board)	State (LSLIC, <\$10k threshold, verify)	State (LSLIC mechanical)	Home Improvement Contractor rules for \$7,500-\$75,000 jobs	Restrictive	Statewide LSLIC; even small trade jobs need a licensed plumber/electrician.	Complete	lsibc.gov
Maine	No state license required	No state GC license; local business license	None for GC work (written contract required > \$3,000)	State (OPOR)	State (OPOR)	Local/home for electric/HVAC; state for oil/gas (verify)	Home Construction Contracts Act — written contract mandatory if ≥ \$3,000	Mixed / caution	No GC license, but plumbing/electrical are state-licensed; enforce the \$3,000 written-contract rule.	Complete	maine.gov (OPOR)
Maryland	No standalone — MHIC (Home Improvement Commission) license required	MHIC required for essentially all home improvement; no \$ minimum	None (any home improvement triggers MHIC)	State (MD Plumbing Board)	State (Unified electrician license, 2025)	State (HVACR)	MD Home Construction Law — all home-improvement contracts must be written	Restrictive	No minor-repair exception; even a toilet flapper or ceiling fan implicates licensing.	Complete	labor.maryland.gov/licensing/mhic
Massachusetts	No standalone — HIC registration required for residential work	CSL required for structural work over \$5,000 or R; no \$ trigger	None for HIC (all home improvement on 1-4 unit owner-occupied)	State	State	State (refrigeration/sheetrock)	M.G.L. c.142A — written contract required over \$1,000	Caution	HIC registration needed even for small jobs; trades separately state-licensed.	Complete	mass.gov; servicetitan.com
Michigan	No standalone — exempt only under \$600	Residential Maintenance & Alteration Contractor license required for work over \$600	\$600 (combined labor + materials)	State	State	State (mechanical)	MI Occupational Code requires written residential contractors (verify exact \$ trigger)	Caution	The \$600 cap is low, so most repairs need an M&A license; only limited no-alteration exceptions.	Complete	michigan.gov (LARA)
Minnesota	No standalone — exempt if single skill area or under receipts cap	Residential contractor/remodeler license if serving 1+ special skill area	< \$15,000 gross annual receipts (with Certificate of Exemption)	State (MN Plumbing Board)	Local (no statewide HVAC license) — verify	Local (no statewide HVAC license) — verify	MN Ch. 326B = warranty statute 327A; residential contractor advised	Mixed / caution	Multi-trade repairs trigger a remodeler license; single-trade or < \$15k receipts exempt.	Complete	dl.mn.gov
Mississippi	No state license; small repairs exempt	Yes — commercial/in-residential > \$50,000+; residential remodeler > \$10,000+	Residential remodel under \$10,000	Local (municipal)	Local (MSB/CB covers contractors above threshold)	State (MSB/CB above thresholds; techs local)	Residential Builders Law — licensed builder for contracts over \$10,000	Mixed / caution	Minor like-for-like repairs under \$10k largely exempt; watch local trade rules.	Complete	msboc.us
Missouri	No state license; local rules only	No state GC license; local (St. Louis, KC, Springfield)	n/a statewide; depends on city ordinance	Local	State (opt-in statewide) + Local	State (opt-in statewide) + Local	None statewide (workmen's comp required, RSMo 207)	Favorable	Among the most permissive — compliance is driven entirely by largely city ordinances.	Complete	servicetitan.com
Montana	No handyman exemption; contractor registration applies broadly	Registration (no exam), applies broadly with no \$ minimum	None — registration required for most work (verify small-job exemption)	State (Board of Plumbers)	State (State Electrical Board)	Local (register with DLI as contractor)	Montana Consumer Protection Act; no specific written-contract \$ trigger (verify)	Restrictive	Registration plus state plumbing/electrical licenses make trade repairs harder.	Complete	servicetitan.com; boards.bdl.mt.gov
Nebraska	No — registration if annual work exceeds \$5,000	Registration (not license) via Dept. of Labor & Regulation	\$5,000 per calendar year	Local (Omaha/Lincoln)	State (State Electrical Division)	Local (municipal)	None notable statewide (verify); local ordinances vary	Mixed / caution	Cheap \$25 registration; electrical needs a state license, plumbing/HVAC local.	Complete	statearequirement.com
Nevada	No — state contractor license needed for nearly all work	Yes — license required above \$1,000 (labor + materials)	< \$1,000 total, no permit, no regulated trade (very narrow)	State (NSCB)	State (NSCB)	State (NSCB)	NRS Ch. 624; written-contract \$ threshold — verify	Restrictive	Electrical/plumbing/HVAC repairs need a state license at any dollar amount.	Complete	nvcncontractorboard.com
New Hampshire	No — no state general/handyman license (municipal only)	No state GC license	n/a (no general licenses); trades self-regulated	State	State	State	Consumer Protection Act RSA 358-A; no \$ threshold	Favorable	General & HVAC repairs need no state license; only electrical/plumbing require state licensure.	Complete	servicetitan.com; oplc.nh.gov
New Jersey	Yes — Home Improvement Contractor registration required	Registration (not GC license) required for home improvement over \$500	< \$500 job value	State	State	State	Consumer Fraud Act N.J.A.C. 17:45A-16 — written contract required \$500+	Caution	Must register as HIC (\$500k liability); electrical/plumbing/HVAC need separate state licenses.	Complete	njcconsumerfairness.gov
New Mexico	No — CID contractor license required above threshold	Yes — license required for jobs over \$7,200/yr	< \$7,200/yr total (minor-work exempt)	State (CID, MM)	State (CID, EE)	State (CID, MM)	Construction Industries Licensing Act, NMSA Ch. 60-12; no notable written-contract \$ threshold	Mixed / caution	Small repairs under \$7,200 exempt, but regulated-trade work still needs a CID license (verify).	Complete	rid.nm.gov
New York	No statewide license; regulated locally (NYC/Nassau/Suffolk/Westchester)	No statewide GC license	n/a statewide; set by locality (verify each)	Local (NYC Master Plumber via DOB)	Local (NYC Master/Electrical)	Local (varies; verify)	GBL Article 36-A — written contract for home improvement over \$500	Restrictive	Local HIC licenses cover 'repair' broadly; a minor-repair exemption is unlikely in the big markets.	Complete	nyc.gov; NY GBL Art. 36-A
North Carolina	No — legal only under GC threshold and trade exemptions	Yes — required at \$40,000+ (G.S. 87-1)	Under \$40,000 (GC only)	State (minor repair/replacement exempt)	State (NCEBEC; no small-job exemption — tightest trade)	State (heating; minor like-for-like repair exempt)	No notable written-contract threshold; Statute of Frauds only	Mixed / caution	Electrical is the compliance risk — even minor repairs need a licensed electrician; plumbing/HVAC have minor-repair carve-outs.	Complete	ncdcb.org; ncebce.org
North Dakota	No dedicated handyman license	Yes — state contractor license required above \$4,000	\$4,000 (includes labor + materials)	State (ND Plumbing Board); no dollar repair exemption	State (NDSEB; notice above \$500)	Local (municipal, Fargo/Bismarck)	No specific home-improvement statute; NDDC 51-16 consumer fraud applies	Mixed / caution	Plumbing/electrical need state licenses regardless of size; HVAC/appliance/networking local.	Complete	sos.nd.gov; ndseb.com
Ohio	No statewide handyman license	No statewide GC license; regulated locally	n/a statewide (trade + local rules apply)	State (OCCLB commercial; residential LOCAL)	State (OCCLB commercial; residential LOCAL)	State (OCCLB residential LOCAL)	HSSA (CRC 1345.21) > \$25, 3-day cancel; HSSA written contract at \$25,000+	Favorable	Residential minor repairs not outside OCCLB — only local permit/licensing apply (verify per city).	Complete	com.ohio.gov (OCCLB)
Oklahoma	No — no statewide GChandyman license	No state GC license; local permit/registration vary (e.g., OKC)	none statewide (no GC license exists)	State (CIB)	State (CIB)	State (CIB mechanical)	No notable home-improvement statute; general statute of frauds only (verify)	Favorable	General repairs need no state license, but trade work (electrical/plumbing/HVAC) is state-regulated even without minor.	Complete	servicetitan.com; cib.ok.gov
Oregon	No — but CCB contractor license required for essentially all paid work	Yes — CCB license, no dollar minimum	none — any paid contractor/repair triggers CCB	State (Building Codes Division)	State (BCD)	State (CB/CB/C mechanical)	No specific written-contract \$ trigger identified — verify	Restrictive	Outlier: no small-job exemption — even minor like-for-like repairs require CCB registration.	Complete	oregon.gov/CCB
Pennsylvania	No state license; HIC registration if > \$5,000/yr revenue	No GC license; HIC registration triggered at \$5,000 annual revenue	< \$5,000/yr revenue + no registration	Local (municipal)	Local (municipal)	Local (some cities)	HICPA (73 P.S. §517) — written contract required for jobs > \$500	Mixed / caution	Register HIC with the AG if revenue > \$5k; written contract mandatory over \$500.	Complete	attorneygeneral.gov
Rhode Island	No — contractor registration required for jobs > \$500	Registration (not license) required when one contract exceeds \$500	< \$500 per contract	State (DLT)	State (DLT)	State (DLT)	Contractor Registration Act; written contract expected — verify \$ trigger	Caution	Low \$500 trigger catches nearly all jobs; trades separately state-licensed.	Complete	dlr.ti.gov
South Carolina	No standalone — work > \$500 needs registration	Yes — commercial GC > \$5,000; residential builder for home building	\$500 (labor + materials)	State (LLR)	State (LLR)	State (LLR mechanical)	\$5k surety bond for projects > \$5,000; SC Uniform Trade Practices Act (verify written-contract rule)	Restrictive	Very low \$500 trigger; even minor trade repairs likely need a state license.	Complete	lr.sc.gov
South Dakota	No state handyman license required	No state GC license; local licensing may apply	None statewide (excise tax license applies)	State (SD Plumbing Commission)	State (SD Electrical Commission)	Local (no state HVAC license; e.g., Sioux Falls)	No notable statewide home-improvement statute (verify); 2% contractor excise tax	Favorable	Only electrical/plumbing are gated by the state; HVAC & handyman handled locally.	Complete	adl.sd.gov; harborcompliance.com
Tennessee	No — Home Improvement license \$3,000-\$24,999 in certain counties only	Yes — state contractor license required at \$5,000+	< \$3,000 generally unregulated (counties vary)	State (full > \$25K; Limited Licensed Plumber for under \$25,000)	State (full > \$25K; Limited Licensed Electrician for under \$25,000)	State (HVAC/mechanical)	TH Consumer Protection Act; Home Improvement written-contract rules in named counties	Mixed / caution	High \$25K GC threshold helps, but LLELP licenses are still needed for trade work.	Complete	tn.gov/commerce/regboards/contractors
Texas	No statewide handyman license required	No state GC license; local city rules vary	None statewide (local permits vary)	State (TX State Board of Plumbing Examiners)	State (TLDR)	State (TLDR ACR)	Residential Construction Liability Act; homeowner work > \$5,000 needs written contract for mechanics' lien (verify)	Favorable	No GChandyman gate, but electrical/plumbing/HVAC are strictly TLDR-licensed at the state level.	Complete	txlsis.texas.gov
Utah	No license; exemption ceiling raised to < \$7,000 (was \$3,000)	Yes — required above \$7,000 (labor + materials aggregate)	< \$3,000 no filing; \$3,000-\$7,000 needs DOP/L affiliation + insurance	State (DOPL) — excluded from exemption	State (DOPL) — excluded from exemption	State (DOPL) — excluded from exemption	26 U.S.A. §5509 — written contract when labor + materials exceed \$10,000	Restrictive	The handyman exemption bars electrical/plumbing/HVAC/gas at ANY price — all core trades need state licenses.	Complete	dopl.utah.gov; le.utah.gov (56-55-305)
Vermont	No — no statewide handyman license	No true license; registration required for jobs over \$10,000 (26 V.S.A. §5501)	\$10,000 (contracts ≤ \$10k need no registration)	State (Division of Fire Safety); some owner-occupied exemptions	State (Electricians' Board); no minor-repair exemption	State (partial) — AChrefrigeration (CB) & gas/oil need ES license	26 V.S.A. §5509 — written contract when labor + materials exceed \$10,000	Mixed / caution	No handyman/GC license, but electrical/plumbing and AC-refrigeration work are state-licensed.	Complete	sos.vermont.gov; firesafety.vermont.gov
Virginia	No standalone handyman license	Yes — contractor license required once a single job exceeds \$1,000	\$1,000 or less (de minimis)	State (DPOR at any size)	State (DPOR at any size)	State (DPOR at any size)	18VAC50-22 — written contract for all licensed contractor work; no separate \$ trigger	Caution	Repairs over \$1,000 need a Class C license PLUS a trade-specific DPOR tradesman license (trade license required at any size).	Complete	dpor.virginia.gov
Washington	No standalone — must register as a contractor with L&I	Yes — all contractors register with L&I; no dollar trigger	< \$500 aggregate contract exempt (RCW 18.27.090, can't split)	State (L&I plumber certification)	State (L&I electrician cert + electrical contractor license)	State (electrical portion needs L&I specialty cert + reg)	No notable state written-contract \$ threshold (verify)	Restrictive	Near-zero de minimis (\$500, can't split jobs); electrical & plumbing each need separate state certifications.	Complete	lni.wa.gov
West Virginia	No dedicated — Contractor License applies once threshold met	Yes — required at \$2,500+ (WV Div. of Labor; some guides cite \$3,000 — verify)	Under \$2,500 total job cost	State (WV Div. of Labor)	State (WV State Fire Marshal)	State (WV Div. of Labor)	WV Consumer Credit & Protection Act (Ch. 46A); no narrow fixed \$ threshold — verify	Restrictive	Low \$2,500 threshold plus state trade licensing means most repairs need licensed trades.	Complete	labor.wv.gov
Wisconsin	No state handyman license; unpermitted minor repairs generally exempt	Yes (residential) — Dwelling Contractor Cert + Qualifier for permit work	n/a — trigger is 'requires a building permit, not dollars'	State (DPSB)	State (DPSB)	State (DPSB; verify scope)	ATCP 110 Home Improvement Practices — written contract by terms, no \$ threshold	Mixed / caution	Trades are state-licensed and ATCP 110 imposes strict contractor/disclosure rules; many cities add local licenses.	Complete	atcp.wi.gov; dps.wi.gov
Wyoming	No state handyman/contractor license; local rules only	No state GC license; municipalities license (Cheyenne, Casper)	None at state level; check each municipality	Local (municipal)	State (WV Dept. of Fire Prevention & Electrical Safety)	Local (municipal)	No notable state home-improvement contract statute — verify	Favorable	Only electrical is state-regulated; plumbing/HVAC & GC vary entirely by city — map target municipalities.	Complete	wyefire.wyo.gov

Early Bird — State Licensing: Key Insights

Cross-cutting findings across all 50 states. Compiled July 2026 from public sources — not legal advice. Verify with each state board and local building department before launch.

The picture at a glance

Favorable	10 states — no state handyman/GC license (but trades are still separately licensed almost everywhere). Best fit for launch on general/appliance/networking work.
Caution / Mixed	25 states — workable with real constraints: low thresholds, fragile exemptions, registration requirements, or trades split state/local.
Restrictive	15 states — core trades state-licensed with no/low exemption, or state registration required for all paid work.

What the data tells us

The trades are the real constraint

In the large majority of states, electrical, plumbing, and HVAC are licensed as separate trades — often with NO 'minor repair' or 'like-for-like' exemption — even where general handyman work is completely unregulated. Early Bird's electrical/plumbing/HVAC scope is the legally sensitive part almost everywhere.

Appliance & networking = lightest burden

These two categories carry the lightest regulation nationwide and are the safest to lead with — with ONE notable exception: Georgia licenses low-voltage/networking through its own board. Always scan each state for niche trade boards, not just the big three.

Arizona is the clearest standout

Its single \$1,000 ROC exemption applies to the trades too, so genuine minor like-for-like electrical/plumbing/HVAC repairs under \$1,000 (no permit) are legal unlicensed — the most model-friendly rule in the country.

'No state license' does NOT mean 'no rules'

Several favorable-looking states (Kansas, Missouri, Ohio, Wyoming, and New York) push licensing to the city/county level. Kansas/Missouri/Wyoming are genuinely light; New York is actually restrictive because local Home Improvement licenses cover 'repair' broadly.

Registration states: low bar, real process

Connecticut (\$200), New Jersey (\$500), Rhode Island (\$500), Pennsylvania (\$5k revenue), Massachusetts, Maryland, Michigan (\$600), plus Alaska, Oregon, and Washington require registration/licensing for essentially all work. Cheap to register, but you must register and use compliant written contracts.

Hardest markets to enter early

Oregon and Washington (license/registration for ANY paid work, no minimum), Nevada, Alaska, Maryland, Louisiana, Utah, Florida, and Hawaii are the most restrictive — trades state-licensed with little or no exemption. Expect to work through licensed partners there.

Home-improvement contract laws vary widely

Many states require a written contract above a low threshold — \$150 (IN), \$200 (CT), \$500 (CA/NJ/NY/PA), \$1,000 (IL/MA), \$3,000 (ME), \$10,000 (VT) — usually with a 3-day cancellation notice. Build the in-app agreement to satisfy the strictest applicable rule per market.

Thresholds are combined labor + materials

Where a dollar exemption exists, it almost always counts labor AND materials, and splitting one job into smaller tickets to stay under a cap is illegal everywhere. Gate jobs on the total value and on whether a permit is required.

Recommended operating rule

Standing policy	Treat electrical, plumbing, and HVAC as 'confirm-before-offer' in every state; lead with appliance and networking (lightest burden); route trade work to licensed partners in Restrictive states; make the in-app contract satisfy each state's home-improvement law; and always verify current thresholds with the state board and local building department before launch. Several figures in the Comparison tab are marked 'verify' where public sources conflicted (e.g., West Virginia's \$2,500 vs \$5,000 threshold, Utah's \$7,000 exemption).
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How to read the Comparison tab

State	The U.S. state.
Statewide handyman license?	Whether the state requires a specific handyman/home-improvement credential for general work.
Statewide GC license (threshold)	Whether a general-contractor license exists at the state level and the job value that triggers it.
Unlicensed \$ threshold	Project value (labor + materials) below which general handyman work needs no license. 'none'/'n/a' where none applies.
Plumbing / Electrical / HVAC	Whether each trade is licensed at the STATE or LOCAL level (or not separately). The key columns for Early Bird's scope.
Consumer / contract law	Home-improvement/consumer statutes and the \$ threshold that triggers a required written contract or cancellation notice.
Early Bird implication	Rating of how workable the state is: Favorable (green), Caution/Mixed (amber), Restrictive (red).
Research status	'Complete' = profiled in this rollout.
Primary source(s)	Key sources used; full per-state citations live in the profile documents.
Disclaimer	Compiled July 2026 from public sources (state licensing boards, contractor-licensing guides, legal summaries). Rules change and vary by city/county — this is not legal advice. Confirm every entry with the relevant authority and have counsel review before operating.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
1	Recurring / Subscription	HVAC filter replacement	Quarterly or per-manufacturer interval	100%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Universal need. The anchor SKU for any membership plan.
2	Recurring / Subscription	Smoke and CO detector battery and test	Annual battery plus function test, all units	100%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Universal, fast, and a genuine safety service.
3	HVAC	Dirty or clogged air filter	Restricted airflow: weak output, short cycling, frozen coil	95%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Highest-frequency HVAC issue in existence. Anchor of any subscription plan.
4	Home Maintenance	Clogged gutters	Overflow, water at foundation, ice damming	85%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium (ladder)	Yes	Twice yearly. Cornerstone of a maintenance plan.
5	Recurring / Subscription	Gutter cleaning	Spring and fall	85%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium (ladder)	Yes	Twice yearly, highly predictable, easy to route in batches.
6	Recurring / Subscription	Outdoor faucet winterization	Hose removal, shutoff, freeze prevention	80%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Seasonal, prevents an expensive burst-pipe claim.
7	Internet	No internet - modem/router needs reboot	Gateway locked up, needs power cycle	70%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Trivial fix, real perceived value.
8	Recurring / Subscription	Refrigerator water filter change	Every 6 months per manufacturer	70%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Trivial labor, recurring parts margin.
9	Plumbing	Clogged toilet	Bowl won't drain or overflows	65%	Yes	Yes	None in practice	Low	No	Plunger / closet auger. Zero enforcement risk.
10	Recurring / Subscription	Water softener salt refill	Monthly to quarterly depending on hardness	65%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Heavy bags customers hate carrying. Strong subscription fit in hard-water NW Indiana.
11	Electrical	Chirping smoke or CO detector	Low battery, or end-of-life sealed unit	60%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Battery units fully yours. High gratitude, low effort.
12	Recurring / Subscription	Dryer vent cleaning	Annual; more often for large households	60%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium (fire)	Yes	Fire prevention. Best margin-to-effort ratio on this list.
13	Electrical	Tripped breaker	Circuit dead; breaker in middle or off position	55%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Reset once. A second trip is a fault - stop.
14	Home Maintenance	Interior paint scuffs and touch-up	Wear in hallways, stairwells, kids' rooms	55%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Easy filler work between service calls.
15	Internet	Slow speeds	Not getting the speeds being paid for	55%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Wired test at the gateway isolates ISP from Wi-Fi.
16	Plumbing	Slow tub or shower drain	Hair buildup at the strainer or trap	55%	Yes	Yes	Grey - low risk	Low	No	Hand snake through the opening. Non-pressurized.
17	Recurring / Subscription	Condensate line flush	Annual, before cooling season	55%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Prevents the single most common summer AC failure.
18	Recurring / Subscription	Condenser coil cleaning	Annual, spring	55%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Pairs naturally with the condensate flush as a spring visit.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
19	Electrical	Tripped GFCI (including upstream device)	Outlets dead; controlling GFCI is in another room	50%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Bathroom GFCI often feeds garage and exterior. Huge share of 'dead outlet' calls.
20	Home Maintenance	Bathroom caulk failure at tub or shower	Cracked, moldy, or missing caulk bead	50%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Prevents real water damage. Natural annual inspection item.
21	Internet	Wi-Fi dead zones	No signal in bedrooms, basement, or garage	50%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Site survey and router relocation. High-margin.
22	Plumbing	Slow bathroom sink drain	Hair and soap on the pop-up assembly	50%	Yes	Yes	Grey - low risk	Low	No	Same as above.
23	Recurring / Subscription	Dishwasher filter cleaning	Quarterly	50%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Most owners don't know the filter exists.
24	Recurring / Subscription	Sump pump test	Semiannual; critical before spring thaw	50%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	Yes	Porter County basements make this an easy sell.
25	Home Maintenance	Door won't latch	Strike plate misaligned from settling or humidity	45%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Five-minute fix, very high satisfaction.
26	Home Maintenance	Squeaky door hinges	Dry or worn hinge pins	45%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Trivial add-on to any visit.
27	Plumbing	Running or phantom-flushing toilet	Failed flapper or fill valve	45%	Yes	Grey Zone	State Plumbing	Low	No	Diagnosis safe. Get counsel's read before replacing parts.
28	Recurring / Subscription	Range hood filter cleaning or replacement	Quarterly	45%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Fast add-on during any kitchen visit.
29	Home Maintenance	Drywall nail pops and small holes	Seasonal movement, furniture damage, removed fixtures	42%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Patch, sand, touch-up. Core handyman work.
30	Appliances	Garbage disposal jammed or humming	Foreign object binding the impeller	40%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Hex key from below plus reset button. Two minutes.
31	HVAC	Clogged condensate drain line	Full pan trips float switch; AC stops silently in summer	40%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Top summer no-cool call. Annual flush prevents it entirely.
32	Home Maintenance	Mildew in bathroom	Poor ventilation, inadequate exhaust run time	40%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Often solved by fixing the exhaust fan or adding a timer.
33	Internet	Streaming buffering	Bandwidth saturation, DNS, or QoS misconfiguration	40%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
34	Plumbing	Dripping faucet	Worn cartridge, washer, or O-ring	40%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	Low	No	Pressurized supply side. Diagnose and refer.
35	Recurring / Subscription	Furnace humidifier pad replacement	Annual, before heating season	40%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Bundles with the fall filter change.
36	Appliances	Dishwasher not draining	Clogged filter, kinked hose, blocked air gap	38%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Check for a disposal knockout plug never removed.
37	Home Maintenance	Cabinet door misaligned or loose hinge	Sagging door, won't close flush	38%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Adjustment takes minutes.
38	Electrical	Flickering or buzzing LED bulbs	Non-dimmable bulb on a dimmer, or incompatible dimmer	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Bulb swap is yours. Dimmer replacement is not.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
39	HVAC	Condenser coil blocked by debris	Leaves, grass, cottonwood, shrubs grown in too close	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Rinse coil, clear 2 ft. Natural spring tune-up item.
40	HVAC	Thermostat batteries dead	Blank display, system unresponsive	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Two-minute fix people routinely call a contractor for.
41	Home Maintenance	Bathroom exhaust fan noisy or weak	Dust-clogged blower, disconnected duct in attic	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Ties directly to the mildew complaint.
42	Home Maintenance	Furniture assembly, TV mounting, shelving	Flat-pack builds, wall mounts, closet systems	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Pure revenue, zero regulatory exposure.
43	Internet	Smart device won't connect to Wi-Fi	Device needs 2.4 GHz; band steering blocking it	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Very common with cameras, plugs, thermostats.
44	Plumbing	Clogged aerator or showerhead	Mineral scale reducing flow	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Unscrew, descale, reinstall. Natural recurring item in hard-water areas.
45	Recurring / Subscription	Bathroom exhaust fan cleaning	Annual	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Prevents the mildew complaints above.
46	Recurring / Subscription	Garage door lubrication and balance check	Annual	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	Yes	Inspect only - never adjust springs.
47	Recurring / Subscription	Refrigerator coil cleaning	Annual	35%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Extends appliance life measurably. Easy to justify.
48	Recurring / Subscription	Whole-house water filter cartridge change	Every 3 to 6 months	35%	Yes	Grey Zone	Grey - plumbed	Low	Yes	Cartridge swap on an existing housing. Installing the system is plumbing.
49	Home Maintenance	Window screen torn	Pets, storms, general age	32%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Re-screening is cheap and easy to batch.
50	Appliances	Dryer not drying (clogged vent)	Long cycles, hot laundry room, lint at exterior hood	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium (fire)	Yes	Genuine fire-hazard fix. Best recurring service on the list.
51	Appliances	Refrigerator not cooling	Condenser coils packed with dust and pet hair	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Coil cleaning solves a large share. High margin.
52	Electrical	Overloaded circuit	Space heater plus microwave on one 15A circuit	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Advisory only. Zero risk, real value.
53	HVAC	Blocked or closed supply registers / returns	Furniture over returns, dampers left in seasonal position	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Explains most room-to-room temperature complaints.
54	HVAC	Thermostat set wrong (mode/schedule)	Heat vs cool, fan AUTO vs ON, schedule overriding manual	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Pure education. Photograph settings before changing.
55	Home Maintenance	Sticking door or window	Humidity swelling, settling, paint buildup	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Plane, adjust, or lubricate.
56	Home Maintenance	Weatherstripping worn on exterior door	Visible daylight, drafts, higher bills	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Natural fall inspection item.
57	Internet	ISP outage vs local fault	Nothing works; unclear whose problem it is	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Isolating this saves a wasted provider appointment.
58	Smart Home & Security	Doorbell camera won't connect to Wi-Fi	Weak signal at the door, or 2.4 GHz band issue	30%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Extremely common. Fully yours.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
59	Appliances	Dishwasher not cleaning dishes	Clogged spray arms, low inlet temp, wrong detergent	28%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours end to end.
60	Appliances	Washer won't drain	Coin trap / drain pump filter clogged	28%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	A sock or coin in the pump filter is extremely common.
61	Electrical	Light fixture failure / replacement	Fixture dead or being upgraded	28%	Yes	No	Local Electrical	Low	No	Line-voltage fixture work is licensed.
62	Home Maintenance	Garage door won't close	Photo eye misaligned or obstructed	28%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Usually a 60-second realignment.
63	Home Maintenance	Grout cracking or missing in tile	Movement, age, moisture	28%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	RegROUT and seal.
64	Home Maintenance	Loose towel bar, grab bar, or accessory	Failed drywall anchors	28%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Grab bars especially - anchor into blocking, not drywall.
65	Smart Home & Security	Smart bulbs or plugs unresponsive	Lost pairing, firmware update, hub offline	28%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
66	Home Maintenance	Loose or damaged downspout	Separated at seam, discharging at foundation	26%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Pairs with every gutter cleaning.
67	Smart Home & Security	Security camera offline	Wi-Fi drop, power loss, firmware issue	26%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
68	Appliances	Appliance won't power on	Tripped GFCI, unplugged, failed cord or outlet	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Check power before assuming appliance failure.
69	Appliances	Ice maker not producing	Frozen or kinked supply line, arm up, clogged screen	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Mostly a water-supply diagnosis.
70	HVAC	Tripped condensate float safety switch	System locked out after pan filled	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Clear the cause first, then reset.
71	Home Maintenance	Squeaky floor	Subfloor separation from joists	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Screws from below where accessible.
72	Internet	Mesh system setup or bad node placement	Nodes too far apart or clustered in one room	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Most self-installs put nodes in the wrong places.
73	Phone	Smartphone settings problems for seniors	Ringer muted, Do Not Disturb stuck on, contacts lost	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Not glamorous, but drives referrals in this demographic.
74	Recurring / Subscription	Caulk inspection and refresh	Annual, wet areas and exterior	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Cheap prevention against expensive water damage.
75	Recurring / Subscription	Irrigation blowout and spring startup	Seasonal, twice yearly	25%	Yes	Partial	Backflow device	Low	Yes	Verify Indiana backflow tester requirements before touching the device.
76	Recurring / Subscription	Under-sink RO filter change	Every 6 to 12 months	25%	Yes	Grey Zone	Grey - plumbed	Low	Yes	Same grey zone as the whole-house filter.
77	Recurring / Subscription	Weatherstripping and draft inspection	Annual, fall	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Natural fall visit component.
78	Recurring / Subscription	Whole-home safety and systems audit	Annual walkthrough with a written report	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Your highest-value recurring product - and it generates repair leads.
79	Smart Home & Security	Smart lock battery dead	Batteries drained faster than expected	25%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Natural recurring check item.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
80	Home Maintenance	Cabinet drawer slide broken	Drawer drags, falls, or won't close	24%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Straightforward parts replacement.
81	Home Maintenance	Exterior caulk failure at windows and trim	Gaps allowing water and air intrusion	24%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Annual exterior inspection item.
82	Smart Home & Security	Automations or routines broken after app update	Scenes stopped firing, schedules lost	24%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours. Recurring by nature - apps update constantly.
83	Appliances	Washer won't spin	Unbalanced load, failed lid switch	22%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
84	Electrical	Dead outlet (device failure)	No power at receptacle, upstream OK	22%	Yes	No	Local Electrical	Medium	No	Test at the face only. Replacement is licensed.
85	Home Maintenance	Garage door opener remote or keypad dead	Battery, reprogramming after power loss	22%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Easy win.
86	Home Maintenance	Wasp, hornet, or bee nest	Nest at eave, deck, or entry	22%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	No	Check whether Indiana pesticide rules apply to for-hire application.
87	Home Maintenance	Water stain on ceiling	Roof leak, plumbing leak, or condensation	22%	Yes	Partial	None to diagnose	Medium	No	Diagnosis is the valuable part. Source determines who fixes it.
88	Smart Home & Security	Voice assistant not recognizing devices	Device names, room assignments, account linking	22%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
89	Appliances	Oven not reaching temperature	Calibration drift or failed bake element	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Also confirm a 240V range hasn't lost one leg.
90	Electrical	Failed light switch	Switch does nothing or is intermittent	20%	Yes	No	Local Electrical	Low	No	Device replacement is licensed in most jurisdictions.
91	HVAC	Tripped breaker or pulled disconnect at unit	No power to air handler or condenser	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Reset once. Repeat trips mean an electrical fault - hand off.
92	Home Maintenance	Bifold or sliding closet door off track	Bent track, worn rollers, misaligned pivot	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Extremely common, five-minute fix, near-zero parts cost.
93	Home Maintenance	Deck board loose, split, or rotted	Age, weather, fastener failure	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	No	Confirm whether the scope triggers a local permit.
94	Home Maintenance	Loose stair railing or handrail	Failed anchors, loose balusters	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium (fall)	No	Real safety item. Anchor into structure.
95	Home Maintenance	Pest entry points (mice, bats, squirrels)	Gaps at soffit, foundation, dryer vent, utility penetrations	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Exclusion work. Confirm whether it triggers Indiana pest-control licensing.
96	Phone	Cell dead zone in the home	Poor carrier coverage indoors	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Wi-Fi calling setup or booster install.
97	Plumbing	Sewer odor indoors	Dry trap in an unused fixture, or vent issue	20%	Yes	Partial	None to fill a trap	Low	No	Running water to refill a trap solves this surprisingly often.
98	Recurring / Subscription	Sump backup battery test and replacement	Annual test, battery every 3 to 5 years	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	Yes	Pairs with the sump test.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
99	Recurring / Subscription	Water heater flush	Annual, sediment removal	20%	Yes	Grey Zone	State Plumbing	Medium	Yes	Commonly done by handymen; strictly it is water-heater maintenance. Get counsel's read.
100	Smart Home & Security	Camera field of view or mounting angle wrong	Covering sky or driveway instead of the door	20%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Remount and re-aim. Easy, visible value.
101	Smart Home & Security	Video doorbell chime not ringing indoors	Chime not configured, or transformer too weak	20%	Yes	Yes	None (low volta	Low	No	Transformer upgrade is low voltage - confirm locally.
102	Appliances	Refrigerator leaking water inside/out	Clogged defrost drain	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Clear the drain tube - classic quick win.
103	Electrical	Ceiling fan wobble or noise	Unbalanced blades, loose downrod or mounting box	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Balancing and tightening fine. Rewiring is not.
104	Electrical	Unlabeled panel / unknown circuits	Homeowner can't find the right breaker	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Circuit mapping is a sellable standalone service, zero exposure.
105	Home Maintenance	Basement humidity or musty smell	Inadequate dehumidification, poor drainage	18%	Yes	Partial	None	Medium	No	Diagnose and advise. Waterproofing is a specialty referral.
106	Home Maintenance	Fogged double-pane window	Failed insulated glass seal	18%	Yes	No	None (specialty	Low	No	Diagnose and refer to a glass specialist. Glass units are not a handyman repair.
107	Home Maintenance	Loose floor tile or vinyl plank	Adhesive failure, subfloor movement	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Small-area repair.
108	Home Maintenance	Window won't stay open	Broken sash balance or spiral balance	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Parts are inexpensive and widely available.
109	Internet	Router still on default admin password	Security exposure; no guest network	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Easy add-on to any network visit.
110	Internet	Smart home devices dropped after router change	New SSID or password broke every device	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Tedious but easy - good billable time.
111	Plumbing	Leaking P-trap slip nut	Drip under the sink, water in the cabinet	18%	Yes	Grey Zone	Grey - non-pres	Low	No	Lowest-risk plumbing repair: gravity drain, reversible.
112	Plumbing	Low water pressure	Whole house or single fixture	18%	Yes	Partial	Grey	Low	No	Gauge at hose bib, check PRV, isolate fixture vs system.
113	Smart Home & Security	Alarm sensor battery dead	Panel showing low-battery fault	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Recurring by design.
114	Smart Home & Security	Camera night vision poor or IR glare	IR reflecting off glass or a nearby wall	18%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Repositioning solves nearly all of these.
115	Appliances	Washer leaking	Burst supply hose, front-loader door gasket	16%	Yes	Partial	None (hose = g	Medium	No	Recommend braided steel hoses - real preventive value.
116	Home Maintenance	Fence gate sagging	Post movement, hinge failure, no anti-sag brace	16%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Anti-sag kit is a fast fix.
117	Home Maintenance	Missing or damaged shingles	Wind damage, age, visible from ground	16%	Yes	Partial	None state / ve	High (fall)	No	Diagnose from ground or drone. Roof work needs fall protection and its own insurance.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
118	Smart Home & Security	Camera storage full or SD card failed	Recording gaps, card errors	16%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Card swap and retention settings.
119	Smart Home & Security	Smart thermostat installation	Homeowner bought one, needs it installed	16%	Yes	Grey Zone	None (24V) - ve	Low	No	Missing C-wire is the usual complication. Low voltage, but at the furnace board.
120	Appliances	Range hood not venting	Grease-clogged filter, disconnected duct, failed fan	15%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Fully yours. Filter cleaning is a recurring item.
121	Electrical	Doorbell not working	Failed transformer, button, or chime	15%	Yes	Yes	None (low volta	Low	No	Low voltage - fully yours including the transformer.
122	HVAC	Frozen evaporator coil	Ice on indoor coil or line set	15%	Yes	Partial	None to thaw	Medium	No	Thaw plus airflow fix is yours. Refrigerant cause is not.
123	Home Maintenance	Deck or fence needs sealing	Graying, water no longer beading	15%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Natural annual or biennial recurring job.
124	Home Maintenance	Dryer vent hood flapper stuck or blocked	Lint buildup or bird nest at exterior hood	15%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Pairs with dryer vent cleaning.
125	Internet	Extender misconfigured / double NAT	Halved bandwidth, devices can't see each other	15%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
126	Phone	Cordless handset not working	Dead battery pack, handset unregistered from base	15%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Battery packs are a cheap stocked part.
127	Plumbing	No hot water	Failed element, thermostat, pilot, or aged tank	15%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	High	No	Diagnose only. Check breaker and setting, then refer.
128	Plumbing	Sump pump failure	Stuck float, unplugged, tripped breaker, dead pump	15%	Yes	Grey Zone	Grey - plug-in u	High	No	Porter County basements. Float and power issues are yours.
129	Smart Home & Security	Keypad code management or rekeying	Codes for guests, contractors, departed housekeepers	15%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Recurring administrative service. Verify Indiana locksmith rules before rekeying for a fee.
130	Smart Home & Security	Smart lock won't align with strike	Deadbolt binding from door or frame movement	15%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	This is a door adjustment problem, not an electronics problem.
131	Appliances	Electric dryer no heat	Blown thermal fuse or failed heating element	14%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	No	Fuse usually blows BECAUSE the vent is blocked - fix both.
132	Electrical	Hardwired smoke detector end of life	Interconnecte d set chirping; 10-year sealed units	14%	Yes	Grey Zone	Local Electrical	Low	No	Battery swap fine. Replacing a hardwired unit is licensed.
133	HVAC	Failed run / start capacitor	Condenser hums but fan won't spin	14%	Yes	Grey Zone	Local HVAC (ve	Medium	No	Common handyman fix in practice; stored charge is a shock hazard.
134	Home Maintenance	Attic insulation insufficient or displaced	High bills, ice dams, uneven temperatures	14%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	No	Diagnosis and top-up. Good energy-audit tie-in.
135	Home Maintenance	Siding loose or damaged	Wind, impact, fastener failure	14%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	No	Small-area repair; large replacement is a referral.
136	Smart Home & Security	Alarm system false alarms	Faulty sensor, pets, misconfigured zone	14%	Yes	Partial	None (verify ala	Low	No	Some states license alarm work. Verify Indiana and Porter County.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
137	Smart Home & Security	Doorbell camera poor battery life	Too many motion events, cold weather, weak Wi-Fi	14%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Usually solved by tuning motion zones.
138	Smart Home & Security	Motion sensor false triggers	Pets, headlights, moving branches, heat sources	14%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Sensitivity and zone tuning.
139	HVAC	Dirty flame sensor (furnace no heat)	Furnace lights then shuts down after seconds	13%	Yes	No	Local HVAC (gas)	High	No	HARD STOP - gas burner compartment despite being a 5-minute fix.
140	Appliances	Dryer loud noise or squealing	Worn drum rollers, idler pulley, or belt	12%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Straightforward parts job, fully unregulated.
141	HVAC	Blower door safety switch not engaged	Panel loose after a filter change; unit won't start	12%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Common after a DIY filter swap.
142	HVAC	Low refrigerant / refrigerant leak	Warm air, ice on line set, long run times	12%	Yes	No	EPA 608 + Local	High	No	Federal EPA 608 required. Non-negotiable.
143	Home Maintenance	Ice dams	Ice ridge at eave, water backing under shingles	12%	Yes	Partial	None	High	No	Seasonal. Address ventilation and insulation, not just the ice.
144	Home Maintenance	Soffit or fascia damage	Rot, animal entry, wind damage	12%	Yes	Partial	None	Medium (ladder)	No	Often discovered during gutter work - natural upsell.
145	Internet	Loose or corroded coax / Ethernet connector	Intermittent drops, degraded splitter, damaged jack	12%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Low voltage - fully yours.
146	Plumbing	Leaking supply stop / angle valve	Drip at the shutoff behind toilet or under sink	12%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	High	No	HARD STOP - tightening a corroded stop shears it and floods the house.
147	Plumbing	Water hammer / banging pipes	Loud knock when a valve closes	12%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	Low	No	Requires arborist install. Diagnose and refer.
148	Recurring / Subscription	Water softener service or resin replacement	Every several years, or on failure	12%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	Medium	Yes	Salt refill is yours. Servicing the unit connects to the supply system - refer.
149	Smart Home & Security	Garage door smart controller setup	MyQ or similar not pairing or reporting wrong state	12%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
150	Smart Home & Security	Guest or family app access management	Family members can't access cameras or locks	12%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Ongoing service opportunity.
151	Smart Home & Security	Hub failure (SmartThings, Hubitat, Alexa, Google)	Whole system unresponsive after hub issue	12%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
152	Smart Home & Security	Smart smoke or CO detector offline	Lost Wi-Fi, needs reconnection after router change	12%	Yes	Partial	None if battery	Low	No	Battery units yours. Hardwired replacement is licensed.
153	Smart Home & Security	Water leak sensor placement and setup	Sensors unplaced, untested, or not alerting	12%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Excellent preventive upsell given your plumbing exposure.
154	Appliances	Dishwasher leaking	Failed door gasket, overfilling, loose hose clamp	10%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	No	Yours unless the fix moves to the supply line.
155	Appliances	Gas range burner won't light	Clogged port, failed igniter, or gas valve	10%	Yes	Partial	Local / gas for	Medium	No	Cleaning a port is fine. Anything at the valve is a hard stop.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
156	Electrical	AFCI nuisance tripping	Breaker trips when a specific appliance runs	10%	Yes	Partial	None to identify	Medium	No	Identify the offending load. Breaker work is licensed.
157	Home Maintenance	Crawlspace vapor barrier displaced	Exposed soil, moisture, musty odor	10%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Straightforward but unpleasant - price accordingly.
158	Home Maintenance	Garage door off track	Roller jumped track, panel binding	10%	Yes	Partial	None	High	No	Only if springs are not involved. Otherwise refer.
159	Internet	No wired drop where one is needed	Office or TV location needs hardwired Ethernet	10%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Low-voltage cabling. Solid upsell.
160	Phone	No dial tone	Fault inside wiring or on the telco side	10%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Isolate at the NID. Carrier-side repairs are free.
161	Plumbing	Loose or rocking toilet	Failed wax ring, loose closet bolts	10%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	Medium	No	Pulling a toilet is clearly regulated work.
162	Smart Home & Security	Camera or router privacy audit	Default passwords, open ports, stale firmware	10%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	Yes	Genuinely valuable annual review.
163	Smart Home & Security	PoE camera has no power	Failed injector, switch port, or damaged cable	10%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Low voltage - fully yours.
164	Home Maintenance	Basement wall crack or water intrusion	Seepage at cove joint or visible crack	9%	Yes	No	None (specialty)	Medium	No	Diagnose and refer. Waterproofing warranties matter to customers.
165	Home Maintenance	Chimney or flashing leak	Water intrusion at chimney, valley, or penetration	9%	Yes	No	None state / vet	High	No	Diagnose and refer to a roofer.
166	Plumbing	Main line backup (multiple fixtures)	Toilets and tubs backing up simultaneously	9%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	High	No	Refer. Often roots or a collapsed line.
167	Smart Home & Security	NVR or DVR not recording	Full drive, failed drive, wrong schedule	9%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
168	Smart Home & Security	New camera cable run needed	Adding a camera where no wiring exists	9%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Low-voltage cabling. Strong margin.
169	Smart Home & Security	Smart switch or dimmer installation	Homeowner bought smart switches, needs install	9%	Yes	No	Local Electrical	Low	No	Line voltage. This is licensed work despite being 'smart home'.
170	Appliances	Microwave not heating	Failed magnetron, diode, or capacitor	8%	Yes	No	None - but don't	CRITICAL	No	HARD STOP - HV capacitor holds a lethal charge when unplugged.
171	Electrical	Whole house outage	No power anywhere	8%	Yes	No	Utility (NIPSCO)	Medium	No	Determine utility side vs main breaker, then call it in.
172	HVAC	Disconnected or leaking duct in crawl/attic	Room won't heat or cool; visible separated duct	8%	Yes	Grey Zone	None (verify location)	Medium	No	Reconnect plus mastic is typically unregulated.
173	HVAC	Thermostat loose wire at baseplate	Intermittent operation; wire backed out of terminal	8%	Yes	Grey Zone	None (24V low voltage)	Low	No	Low voltage generally unregulated - confirm locally.
174	Phone	Static or noise on the line	Bad jack, moisture in NID, failing cordless base	8%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Fully yours.
175	Phone	VoIP / ATA setup after switching providers	Number ported, house wiring not reconnected	8%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Common after any provider change.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
176	Plumbing	Hose bib leak or freeze break	Drip at spigot, or water in wall when opened	8%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	Medium	No	Often a burst frost-free sillcock inside the wall.
177	Plumbing	Sump discharge frozen or blocked	Pump runs but water doesn't leave	8%	Yes	Yes	None	Medium	No	Clearing an exterior discharge line is outside the foundation.
178	Smart Home & Security	Alarm panel takeover or self-monitoring switch	Leaving a monitoring contract, keeping the hardware	8%	Yes	Partial	Verify alarm license	Low	No	Popular cost-saving request. Verify licensing first.
179	Smart Home & Security	Smart thermostat not controlling system correctly	Wrong equipment type configured, staging issues	8%	Yes	Partial	None (24V) - verify wiring	Medium	No	Misconfiguration on can short-cycle equipment.
180	Smart Home & Security	Whole-home smart system consultation	Homeowner wants a plan before buying hardware	8%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Consulting revenue with zero parts cost.
181	HVAC	Failed contactor	Chattering or pitted contacts; unit won't engage	7%	Yes	Grey Zone	Local HVAC (verify license)	Medium	No	Same grey zone as the capacitor.
182	HVAC	Gas valve, pilot, or ignitor failure	No ignition, no heat	7%	Observe Only	No	Local HVAC (gas license)	High	No	HARD STOP - gas train work.
183	Plumbing	Garbage disposal leaking	Leak at flange, drain elbow, or body	7%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	Medium	No	Drain connections. Refer.
184	Appliances	Gas dryer no heat	Failed igniter or gas valve coils	6%	Yes	No	Local / gas	High	No	HARD STOP under the no-gas rule.
185	Home Maintenance	Elevated radon level	Test result above 4.0 pCi/L	6%	No	No	STATE LICENSE	High	No	Indiana licenses radon testing AND mitigation for compensation (410 IAC 5.1). Do not test for a fee unlicensed.
186	Phone	One off-hook phone killing the whole line	A single faulty handset disables every extension	6%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Unplug all, add back one at a time.
187	Plumbing	Water heater leaking from tank	Water on the floor around the heater	6%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	High	No	Tank failure. Shut off supply and refer same day.
188	HVAC	Blower motor failure	No airflow, humming, burning smell	5%	Yes	No	Local HVAC	High	No	Diagnose and refer.
189	Home Maintenance	Garage door spring broken	Loud bang, door will not lift, visible gap in spring	5%	Yes	No	None - but HAF	CRITICAL	No	HARD STOP - torsion springs kill and maim people annually. Refer always.
190	Phone	Voicemail or answering machine setup	Can't retrieve messages or set greeting	5%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Trivial but genuinely valued by older customers.
191	Plumbing	Frozen or burst pipe	No water in a cold snap, or active flooding	5%	Yes	Emergency Only	State Plumbing	CRITICAL	No	Shut off water to stop the loss, then refer. Shutoff is not plumbing work.
192	Electrical	Half the house dead / lost leg / open neutral	Half of circuits out, lights dimming and surging	4%	Yes	No	Utility or Local Electrician	High	No	HARD STOP - destroys electronics, starts fires. Urgent referral.
193	Phone	Bad phone jack or wall plate	Dead extension in one room	4%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Low voltage - unregulated.
194	Phone	Medical alert device setup or range problem	Pendant out of range of base, or untested	4%	Yes	Yes	None	Low	No	Builds strong loyalty in senior households.

Rank	Category	Issue	Common Cause / Symptom	Annual Household Likelihood	Can Diagnose?	Can Fix?	License Required (IN / Porter Co.)	Risk Level	Recurring Revenue?	Notes / Hard Stops
195	Plumbing	Well pump or pressure tank problem	No water, rapid cycling, air spitting from taps	4%	Yes	No	State Plumbing	High	No	Relevant in rural Porter County.
196	Appliances	Refrigerator sealed system failure	Compressor not running, or running constantly	3%	Yes	No	EPA 608	High	No	Sealed refrigerant system. Refer.
197	Electrical	Obsolete panel (Federal Pacific / Zinsco)	Known failure-to-trip panels found on inspection	3%	Yes	No	Local Electrical	High	No	Identify and refer. Real safety finding.
198	Electrical	Warm, discolored, or scorched outlet	Burning smell, melted face, scorch marks	3%	Yes	No	Local Electrical	CRITICAL	No	HARD STOP - active fire risk. Kill the breaker, refer.
199	Electrical	Aluminum branch wiring	Pre-1975 home; connection overheating risk	2%	Yes	No	Local Electrical	High	No	Identify and refer for pigtail / AlumiConn.
200	HVAC	Cracked heat exchanger / CO hazard	CO alarm, soot, flame rollout, headaches	2%	Refer Only	No	Local HVAC (gas)	CRITICAL	No	HARD STOP - evacuate, call NIPSCO. Do not diagnose.

Scope and Revenue Summary by Category								
All figures are live formulas against the Issue Matrix tab.								
Category	Issues	Can Fix	Grey Zone	Partial	Cannot Fix	% Actionable	Recurring Items	Avg Likelihood
Recurring / Sub	25	20	3	1	1	80%	25	47%
Home Maintenance	45	34	0	6	5	76%	7	25%
Smart Home &	30	24	1	4	1	80%	3	16%
Appliances	20	15	0	2	3	75%	3	20%
Internet	12	12	0	0	0	100%	0	32%
HVAC	19	9	4	1	5	47%	4	22%
Electrical	18	8	1	1	8	44%	1	22%
Plumbing	21	5	3	2	11	24%	1	22%
Phone	10	10	0	0	0	100%	0	11%
TOTAL	200	137	12	17	34	69%	44	25%
Membership Plan Sizing								
Recurring items	44							
Of those, fully a	39							
Top-50 ranked i	47							
Top-50 ranked i	1							

Legend, Methodology, and Caveats

Methodology

Rank	Items are sorted by Annual Household Likelihood and numbered 1 to 200. Rank 1 is the issue a household is most likely to experience in a given year.
Annual Household Likelihood	ESTIMATED share of households experiencing this in a typical year. These are informed judgment calls from trade practice, NOT measured data. Replace them with your own call logs after 90 days of operation - that is when this becomes a real planning tool.
Can Fix?	Yes = defensible unlicensed work. Grey Zone = plausible but unsettled; resolve with counsel. Partial = part of the fix is in scope. No = licensed work or a hard safety stop.
Recurring Revenue	Yes = the item recurs on a predictable schedule and can be sold as a membership or subscription rather than a reactive call.
Risk Level	Combined safety and financial exposure if done wrong - not difficulty.

Legal Basis

Plumbing	Licensed statewide under IC 25-28.5. The definition at 25-28.5-1-2(1) covers installation, MAINTENANCE, extension, and alteration of piping, fixtures, and appurtenances. None of the nine exemptions at 25-28.5-1-32 covers a third-party for-hire handyman.
IC 25-28.5-1-36	An unlicensed person cannot sue to recover compensation for work constituting plumbing. A disputed invoice for such work is legally uncollectible.
Electrical / HVAC	No statewide license in Indiana; regulated at city and county level. Sources conflict on this - verify with each jurisdiction directly.
EPA Section 608	Federal. Required for anyone handling refrigerant, regardless of state or local rules.
Radon	Indiana licenses radon testing AND mitigation performed for compensation under 410 IAC 5.1. This is a state requirement with no local workaround.
Porter County	Contractor registration via the Building Department (219-465-3676) plus a \$5,000 unified license bond filed with the county recorder under IC 22-11-3.1-2. Valparaiso, Portage, Chesterton, Hebron, and the Town of Porter each run separate programs.
Still to verify	Pesticide application (wasp nests), pest exclusion, locksmith/rekeying, alarm system work, and backflow device testing may each carry their own Indiana requirements. None were confirmed for this workbook.

Non-Negotiable Hard Stops

Gas	Any gas odor, CO alarm, suspected combustion problem, or work at a gas valve, burner, or heat exchanger. Evacuate, call NIPSCO, do not diagnose.
Garage doors	Torsion springs store enormous energy and kill people every year. Never adjust or replace. Lubrication and balance inspection only.
Microwaves	Never open one. The high-voltage capacitor holds a lethal charge after it is unplugged.
Refrigerant	No refrigerant contact without EPA 608.
Chemical drains	Recommend a company-wide ban. Damages older pipe, injures whoever opens the line next, destroys the diagnosis, costs credibility with licensed partners.
Pressurized systems	Supply stops, compression fittings, valves. A sheared stop floods a house in minutes.
Repeat breaker	One reset is diagnosis. A second trip is a fault - stop and refer.
Roof and ladders	Above single-story eave height requires fall protection, training, and specific insurance. Confirm coverage before quoting any of it.

IMPORTANT

This workbook is a planning and training tool assembled from Indiana statute and general trade practice. It is not legal advice and no attorney has reviewed it. The likelihood figures are estimates, not measured data. Licensing scope is decided by statute, local ordinance, and how a regulator or court characterizes the specific work performed - not by job title or invoice wording. Resolve every Grey Zone entry with an Indiana construction attorney, and confirm the local column with the Porter County Building Department and each municipality you intend to serve, BEFORE any of this becomes technician policy.